A

AcroForm
The interactive form technology of PDF: text fields, check boxes, radio buttons and signature fields that a reader can fill in.

Annotation
An object attached to a page, such as a link, a comment, a highlight or a file attachment icon.

Ascender
The part of a lowercase letter that rises above the x-height, as in b, d and h.

B

Baseline
The imaginary line on which most letters sit; descenders extend below it.

Bleed
Artwork that extends beyond the trim edge of a printed page, so that no white edge remains after cutting.

Bookmark
An entry of the document outline, shown in the navigation panel of a PDF viewer.

C

CMYK
The cyan, magenta, yellow and black color model used for printing.

Content stream
The sequence of drawing operators that paints the text, graphics and images of a PDF page.

Cross-reference table
The index at the end of a PDF file that lists the byte offset of every object, allowing random access.

D

Descender
The part of a letter that extends below the baseline, as in g, p and y.

Digital signature
A cryptographic seal that identifies the signer and proves that the signed part of the document has not been changed.

DocMDP
A certification signature that defines which changes are still allowed after the document has been certified.

E

Embedded file
A file stored inside a PDF, for example the XML invoice data of a ZUGFeRD document.

Embedded font
A font program stored in the PDF, so that the document displays the same on every computer.

Encryption
Protection of the document content with a password and a set of permissions such as printing or copying.

F

Factur-X
The French-German hybrid e-invoice standard, technically identical to ZUGFeRD 2.1 and later.

Font subset
An embedded font that contains only the glyphs used in the document, which keeps the file small.

Footnote
A note placed at the bottom of the page or column that refers to it.

G

Glyph
The visual shape of a character in a particular font.

Gutter
The space between two columns, or between the inner margins of facing pages.

H

Hyphenation
Breaking a word at the end of a line according to the rules of a language.

I

Incremental update
Changes appended to the end of a PDF file without rewriting the original bytes; required for multiple signatures.

J

Justification
Alignment of text to both the left and the right margin by adjusting the word spacing.

K

Kerning
Adjusting the space between specific pairs of letters, such as AV or To, for an even appearance.

L

Leading
The vertical distance between the baselines of two lines of text.

Ligature
Two or more characters joined into a single glyph, such as fi or fl.

LTV
Long-term validation: certificate and revocation data stored in the PDF so that a signature stays verifiable after the certificate has expired.

M

Margin
The empty space between the content area and the edge of the page.

Metadata
Information about the document, such as title, author and creation date, stored in the document information dictionary and as XMP.

O

Orphan
The first line of a paragraph left alone at the bottom of a page or column.

Outline
The hierarchical table of bookmarks of a PDF document.

Overprint
Printing one ink on top of another instead of knocking out the color underneath.

P

PDF/A
The ISO 19005 family of standards for long-term archiving: all fonts embedded, no encryption, no external dependencies.

PDF/UA
The ISO 14289 standard for universally accessible PDF documents, based on a tagged structure.

Point
The basic unit of PDF coordinates and font sizes: 1/72 of an inch.

R

Raster image
An image made of pixels, such as a photograph in JPEG or PNG format.

RGB
The red, green and blue color model of screens.

Running header
Text repeated at the top of every page, such as the chapter title.

S

Serif
A small stroke at the end of the main strokes of a letter; fonts without them are called sans-serif.

Structure tree
The logical structure of a tagged PDF: headings, paragraphs, lists and tables in reading order.

SVG
Scalable Vector Graphics, an XML format for drawings that stay sharp at any size.

T

Tagged PDF
A PDF that contains a structure tree, so that assistive technologies can read it in the right order.

Timestamp
A trusted time issued by a time stamping authority, proving that a signature existed at that moment.

Tracking
Uniformly adjusting the spacing between all letters of a word or a line.

Trim size
The final size of a printed page after cutting.

V

Vector graphics
Graphics described by lines, curves and fills instead of pixels.

W

Watermark
Text or an image drawn across the page, often semi-transparent, such as DRAFT or CONFIDENTIAL.

Widow
The last line of a paragraph left alone at the top of a page or column.

X

XFDF
XML Forms Data Format: an XML file that carries the annotations and form field values of a PDF.

XMP
Extensible Metadata Platform: XML metadata embedded in the PDF, required by PDF/A.

x-height
The height of lowercase letters without ascenders, such as x, a and o.

Z

ZUGFeRD
The German hybrid e-invoice standard: a PDF/A-3 document with the invoice data embedded as XML.